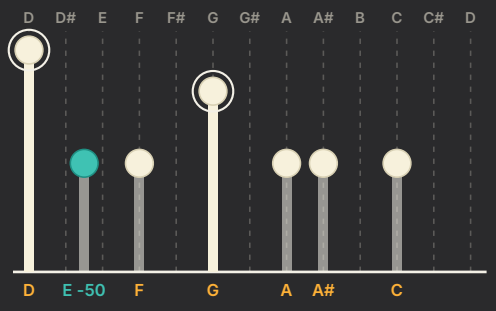
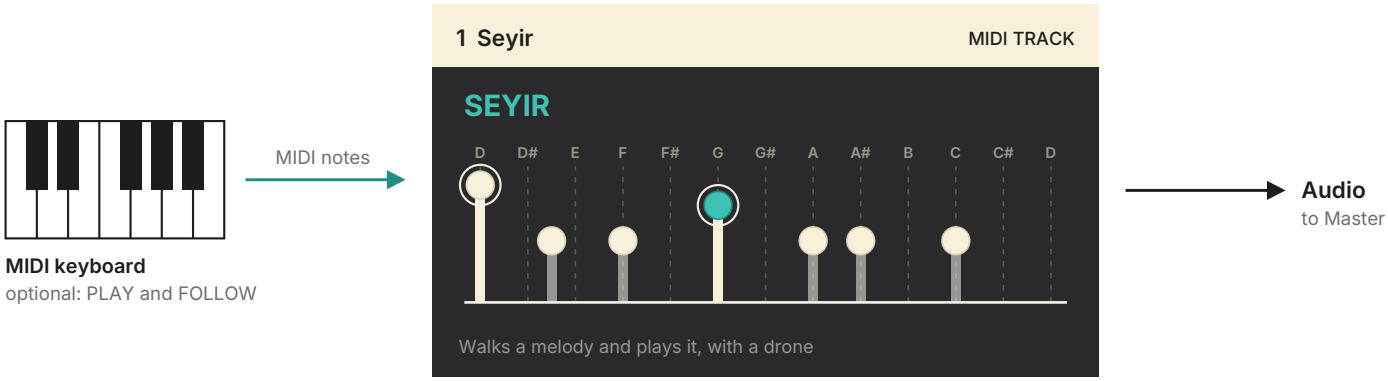
SEYIR

Getting started: exploring microtonal melody in Ableton Live



Maqam Bayati on D, playing E half-flat

Seyir improvises melodies in a maqam, a raga or any tuning you give it, and plays them itself, over a drone. It moves the way a player moves through a mode: mostly by step, leaning on the strong notes, ending phrases on a resting note, and climbing away from the tonic over several phrases before coming home. This guide gets it playing in a couple of minutes, then shows you how to steer it.



One MIDI track. Seyir makes its own sound, so there's nothing to route and no synth to retune.

You'll need

- Ableton Live 11 or 12 (any edition that can load VST3 plug-ins).
- Seyir built and installed. Building it copies **Seyir.vst3** into ~/Library/Audio/Plug-Ins/VST3 for you; a release download goes in the same folder.
- A MIDI keyboard if you want to play along. Seyir walks on its own without one.

> **Why its own sound?** Most synths only play the twelve piano notes. Seyir's voices run inside the plug-in, so every quarter tone and just interval comes out exactly where the scale puts it.

Set up

1 Let Live see Seyir

Open **Live → Settings** (⌘,) and choose the **Plug-Ins** tab. Turn on **Use VST3 Plug-In System Folders**, then press **Rescan**.

In the browser, open **Plug-Ins**. Seyir is under **Taddei**.

2 Put Seyir on a MIDI track

Insert a MIDI track (**Create → Insert MIDI Track**, or ⌘⇧T) and drag Seyir onto it. Its panel opens; if it doesn't, click the wrench on the device.

It starts on maqam **Bayati** on D, with a plucked-string voice and a held drone on D and A.

3 Press play

Press play in Live. Seyir starts walking on the next eighth note: the drone fades in, the melody begins on the tonic, and the display reads **WALKING / SYNCED TO LIVE**. The ladder lights each note as it plays and the PATH strip draws the melody's shape.

Press stop and the melody and the drone stop with it.

> **Nothing?** Check the WALK button is lit (FOLLOW and PLAY wait for your keys), and that the track isn't muted. Troubleshooting on the last page has the full list.

4 Walk without Live's transport

Press **RUN**. Seyir walks at Live's tempo whether Live is playing or not, which is handy while you try modes and turn knobs. The display reads **WALKING / FREE**.

5 Play it yourself

Arm Seyir's track (Live arms it when you select it) and pick how your keys work:

Button	What your keys do
PLAY	Play the scale directly. With KEYS on **SNAP**, each key plays the scale's nearest note: play D E F and you hear D, E half-flat, F. With **WHITE KEYS**, C3 is the tonic and each white key is the next note of the scale, so every note is in reach whatever the tuning. Let go of a key while still holding another and it slides back to the one you're holding.
FOLLOW	Hold a key and a phrase starts on that note and keeps improvising until you let go. Press a new key to move it. While Live plays, the phrase starts on the next step.
WALK	Seyir walks on its own and ignores your keys.

> **First thing to try** Put Seyir in PLAY with KEYS on SNAP and play a slow D minor scale, D E F G A Bb C D, against the drone. Bayati bends your E down a quarter tone. Then switch the mode to Kurd and play it again: now your E plays E-flat.

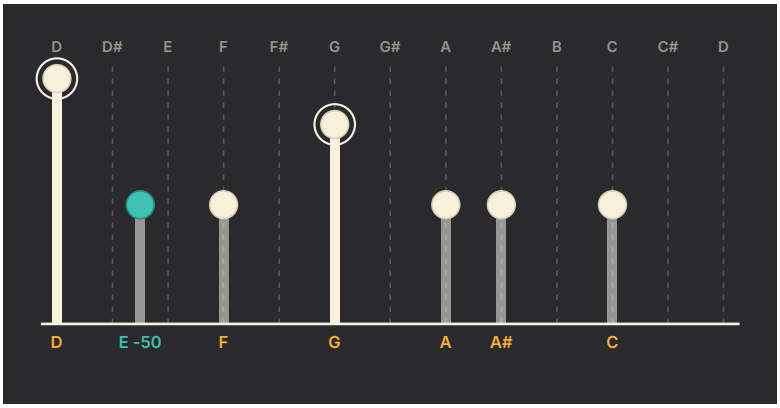
Choose a mode

Click the **MODE** display in the header for the list, or step through it with **<** and **>**. Changing mode keeps the tonic and the drone, so you hear each mode against the same reference. Change the tonic with **TONIC** and **FINE** (in cents) in the SCALE section.

Family	Modes	How they're tuned
Arabic maqam	Rast, Bayati, Hijaz, Saba, Sikah, Huzam, Nahawand, Kurd, Ajam, Nikriz	Quarter tones (24 to the octave), the usual way they're written down. Players place the half-flat notes by ear.
Turkish makam	Rast, Uşşak, Hüseyni, Hicaz, Kürdi, Nihavend	Commas of 1/53 octave, as in Turkish theory. Turkish Rast's third is higher than Arabic Rast's.
Hindustani raga	Yaman, Bhupali, Bhairav, Bhimpalasi, Malkauns, Todi, Marwa, Bhairavi	Just intonation. Each has its own notes going up and coming down, and its vadi and samvadi as strong notes.
Gamelan & more	Slendro, Pelog, Thai 7-equal	One typical tuning each. Every gamelan is tuned its own way.
Just & equal	Harmonics 8-16, Just major, 12-TET major, 24-EDO, Bohlen-Pierce	Reference points. 24-EDO is every quarter tone, for carving your own scale.
Scala file	Anything	**LOAD .SCL** reads a Scala tuning file. The scale is saved with your Live set.

Read the ladder

The SCALE section shows one octave of the mode from the tonic, laid against the piano's notes.



Dashed lines: the piano's twelve notes.

Bar height: how strongly the melody is drawn to the note.

Ring: a resting note. Phrases like to end there.

Amber label: the nearest piano note and how far off it is.

Turquoise: the note sounding now.

Under each note are its cents above the tonic. Small arrows over a note mean it's used only going up or only coming down: maqam Rast climbs through B half-flat and descends through B-flat, and raga Yaman only touches Pa on the way down. Click any note to hear it against the drone.

> **Hear the difference** Play Arabic Rast, then Turkish Rast, with the same tonic. Click the third on the ladder in each: 350 cents, then 385. Then try Yaman's third (386, the pure 5/4) and 12-TET major's (400).

Find your way around



1	Mode	The mode playing now and its family. Click for the list; < and > step through it.
2	Ladder	The scale against the piano's notes. Click to hear a note, drag to reshape (next page).
3	Jins	A maqam's lower and upper cells. Swap the upper one to modulate.
4	Tonic	TONIC, FINE (cents) and RANGE, how high the melody can climb.
5	Files	LOAD .SCL for Scala tunings. RESET NOTES undoes your ladder changes.
6	Path	The melody over the last 14 seconds. Rings mark phrase ends.
7	Display	The note sounding now (nearest piano note, then cents) and what Seyir is doing.
8	Play mode	WALK, FOLLOW or PLAY; RUN to walk without Live; NEW for a fresh walk.
9	Walk	How the melody moves: density, leaps, gravity, arc, phrase length, ornaments.
10	Deja vu	How often steps replay from a loop instead of being invented. Red: locked.
11	Voice	Which synth voice or resonator plays, and its knobs.
12	Shape	Glide, envelope, filter, drive, reverb and level.
13	Drone	Tonic with a fifth, fourth or octave; held or plucked like a tanpura.
14	Header	TIPS shows what each control does when you hover. ALL OFF stops everything.

Steer the melody

Control	What it does
DENSITY	Up: busier, shorter notes. Down: longer notes and more space between phrases.
LEAP	How far one move can jump. Low keeps it stepwise, the way most maqam and raga melodies move.
GRAVITY	How strongly the melody leans on the strong notes (the tall bars), and how surely phrases end on a resting note.
ARC	The seyir: over six phrases the melody climbs away from the tonic and comes back. Up makes the shape clearer; down lets it wander anywhere.
PHRASE	Notes per phrase, 2 to 16. The last one lands on a resting note and is held longer.
ORNAMENT	Chance that a note gets an ornament: a slide in from the last note, a grace note flicked in from the note above, or a shake that swings above the note.
STEP	Length of one step, from 1/4 to 1/32, with triplets.

Reshape the scale

- **Drag a note up or down** to change how strongly the melody is drawn to it. All the way down takes it out of the scale entirely; the melody and your keys skip it. Thin a 24-EDO scale down to five notes and you have a pentatonic of your own.
- **Shift-drag sideways** to retune a note, up to a semitone either way. You hear it as you move. Try moving Bayati's E half-flat between 140 and 170 cents: different regions place it differently.
- **Double-click** a note to undo its changes; **RESET NOTES** undoes them all.

Ladder changes belong to the scale you made them on. Changing the mode or a jins starts from that scale's own notes. They're saved with your Live set.

Modulate with the jins

A maqam is two cells: the lower jins on the tonic and the upper jins on the ghammaz, the note where they meet. Click **UPPER JINS** and pick another: Bayati with Hijaz on top instead of Nahawand, Rast with Nahawand on top. The menu shows each jins's notes in cents. Players modulate exactly this way, and you can do it mid-phrase. Both jins are host parameters, so you can draw the modulation into your arrangement.

Lock a phrase with DEJA VU

DEJA VU remembers the last **LOOP** steps. Turned up, it replays steps from that loop instead of inventing new ones; at noon you get a phrase that keeps coming back with variations. All the way up locks the loop and its LEDs turn red. **NEW** forgets the loop and starts a fresh walk.

> **Try this** Let Seyir walk Bayati until you hear a phrase you like, then turn DEJA VU all the way up to lock it. Now swap the upper jins to Hijaz, then the lower jins to Saba, then to Kurd: the same melody moves through each maqam.

Shape the sound

VOICE picks the model that plays the melody: one of 17 synth voices (plucked string, modal, classic analog, waveshaper, FM, six-op FM, phase distortion, formant, harmonic, wavetable, wave terrain, swarm, particle, speech) or one of four resonators (resonator, sympathetic strings, inharmonic string, FM voice). The three knobs under it are that model's own and change their names to match. DECAY is how long notes ring. COLOR (a low-pass gate) and MOTION (each note's envelope moving the second knob) apply to the synth voices; they're dimmed for the resonators.

SHAPE has GLIDE, ATTACK and SUSTAIN for the envelope, TONE and RES for a low-pass filter, DRIVE, SPACE (reverb, on the melody and the drone) and LEVEL. **DRONE** plays the tonic, alone or with a pure fifth, fourth or octave, either HOLD (steady) or PLUCK (strings struck in a tanpura's cycle, one per beat). It sounds while the melody plays and for a few seconds after you touch a key or the ladder.

Record what it plays

Seyir's notes are microtonal, so record its audio rather than MIDI. Insert an audio track, set its **Audio From** to the Seyir track, arm it and record as usual. Or freeze and flatten Seyir's track. Every knob and button is a parameter Live can automate, mode and jins included.

Troubleshooting

Problem	Fix
Seyir isn't in the browser	Turn on Use VST3 Plug-In System Folders and press Rescan (step 1). Check Seyir.vst3 is in ~/Library/Audio/Plug-Ins/VST3.
Live plays but Seyir doesn't	WALK must be lit. FOLLOW and PLAY wait for keys. Check LEVEL isn't down.
My keyboard plays nothing	Choose PLAY or FOLLOW; WALK ignores keys. Arm Seyir's track. With WHITE KEYS, black keys are silent.
A note never plays	Its bar is all the way down, or it's used only going up or only coming down. Double-click it or press RESET NOTES.
My ladder changes disappeared	Changing the mode or a jins starts from the new scale's own notes.
It clashes with my other tracks	Expected: they're tuned to the piano. Set TONIC (and FINE) to the song's key so the tonics agree, and let the other parts stay on the tonic and fifth.
The drone won't stop	It keeps going for six seconds after you last touched a key or the ladder. Press DRONE to turn it off.

Everything else, control by control, is in the README.